

12. Source: Meeting with the head surgeon of HfA in Beta Town, accompanied by two armed tribespeople.

Upon concluding the meeting with the Patient Association representatives, the HfA delegation arrived at the HfA office. Unexpectedly, two armed individuals, presumably tribal guards, escorted the Head Surgeon of HfA in Beta Town. They left the surgeon with the delegation for few minutes, issuing an explicit warning against any attempts to keep him from returning to his residence. The tribespeople guarded the door of the office.

Once alone, the Head Surgeon described the current situation at the residence. Although telecommunications, including phones and the internet, were cut off, they have essential resources like food, water, and electricity. Armed guards monitor their every move, confining them to the premises with minimal outside contact. The team can send out one member daily for necessities. Overall, they face ennui due to their limited activities.

He articulated the team's growing frustration with HfA's mismanagement of its relationship with local tribal leaders and the lack of clarity about the organization's plans. This mishandling has caused a significant breach of trust between HfA and the local community. Some team members, wary of the volatile security situation, are eager to be repatriated to Switzerland, while others want to continue their work at the hospital.

The delegation assured the surgeon of HfA's commitment to resolving the crisis promptly, explaining their directive from Geneva. They also clarified that due to decisions already made and funding constraints, HfA's long-term presence in Beta Town is not viable. The dispute with tribal leader is seen by many in Geneva, as well as the German donor, as an attempt to extort financial support for the hospital in breach of the mission and trust of HfA. The situation goes against the principles of independence and impartiality of HfA. However, the Head Surgeon urged the delegation to find a middle ground to prevent the current labor dispute from escalating into a real hostage situation, given the organization's strict no-ransom policy.

In parting, the Head Surgeon gave to the delegation a dozen of personal letters from the staff to their families back home. Both parties agreed on reconvening the next day after engaging in discussions with tribal leaders.